money laundering. She may not operate in the wild, but her contributions to the global war on terror cannot be ignored.

Spies who work at the desk as analysts, linguists, cyber exploitation officers, country experts and so on are as important as those in covert ops, but their roles hold none of the glamour that James Bond films have imparted to agents in the field. Nevertheless, their methodical and tireless work at headquarters as well as abroad is always part of the most celebrated operations. A woman officer who started her career as an analyst went on to head a R&AW mission abroad. She is that rare spy: a trove of valuable intelligence on North Korea, Russia, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.

A legendary spy chief once observed that many women IPS officers who could have joined the R&AW but preferred to serve in domestic agencies, such as the paramilitary, the state police or the IB, due to family obligations. Right now, women officers are in charge of very important and sensitive operations within the IB and at least five SIBs (State Intelligence Bureaus, part of the IB) have senior women officers. But whether at the desk or on the field, all go through the same rigorous routine: physical training based on the template of the paramilitary, geopolitics and trade-craft. They also learn how to make friends, merge into the background, conduct surveillance, detect surveillance, run assets, brief and debrief sources, write reports, communicate clandestinely, observe warning signs and conduct covert operations. Human psychology and human weaknesses, topography to assess distances and heights, and ciphering and deciphering techniques are part of their training as well, as are mountaineering, swimming and practical sessions with units in different urban and rural locations.